Betsy & Steve — Complete Bridge Conventions

Betsy & Steve Agreements

Convention Card

Open questions:

- Convention card - Coded 9’s and 10’s

General Approach

System: Standard American | **5-card majors | 1st–4th seat**

Convention Reference

Fully Documented

Convention	What it covers
Major Raises	Bergen, Jacoby 2NT, Splinter, Drury
Inverted Minors	Single raise of opener’s minor
Defense vs. 1NT Interference	After double or suit overcall over partner’s 1NT
NTResponses.md	Stayman, Jacoby Transfers, Texas Transfers
SupportDoubles.md	Support Doubles / Redoubles
RKC1430.md	Roman keycard 1430 slam bidding
NewMinorForcing.md	New Minor Forcing
WONT.md	System for overcalling opponents 1NT
MichaelsCuebid.md	Michaels Cuebid
Unusual2NT.md	Unusual 2NT

Not Yet Adopted - Potentially discuss

- Help suit / game try suit
- Fourth Suit Forcing

Notrump Openings

Bid	Range	Responses	Notes
1NT	15–17 HCP	Stayman; Jacoby Transfers; Texas Transfers	Range **announced**; transfers **announced**
2NT	20–21 HCP	Stayman; Jacoby Transfers; Texas Transfers	Range **announced**; transfers **announced**

After opponent interference over 1NT: see detailed notes

Major Openings (5+ cards, 1st–4th seat)

Response	Points	Support	Notes
2M	6–10	3 cards; or exactly 6 with 4 cards	
Bergen 3♣	10–12	4	**Alertable**
Bergen 3♦	7–9	4	**Alertable**
3M	0–5	4	Preemptive; **alertable**
Jacoby 2NT	13+	4	Game forcing or better; **alertable**
Splinter	13+	4	Singleton/void; **alertable**
Drury 2♣	Medium+	3	Passed hand only; **alertable**
Drury 2♦	Medium+	4	Passed hand only; **alertable**

Minor Openings (3+ cards each)

Response	Points	Notes
Inverted single raise	10+	Forcing; no 4-card major; **alertable**
Double raise	0–9	Preemptive/weak, **alertable**

Two-Level Openings

Bid	Points	Shape	Responses	Notes
2♣	22+	Any	2♦ = waiting	
2♦ / 2♥ / 2♠	5–11	6-card suit	2NT = forcing inquiry	

Overcalls

- **Simple (1-level):** 8–17 HCP
- **Simple (2-level):** 11–17 HCP
- New suit by advancer is non-forcing constructive

Jump overcall: Intermediate — sound when vulnerable, light when non-vulnerable

NT overcalls: - Direct 1NT: 15–18 HCP, systems on (Stayman, transfers) — range **announced** - Balancing 1NT: 12–14 HCP — range **announced** - Jump to 2NT over a **suit** opening: 2 lowest unbid suits (Unusual 2NT) - Over opponent's 1NT: WONT, not Unusual 2NT

Michaels Cuebid: Alertable - Over a minor: both majors - Over a major: other major + a minor

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Doubles

Type	Through	Notes
Negative	3♠	
Support	2♠	
Takeout vs. preempts	4♠	
Takeout + bid: 18+ hcp		

Slam Conventions

RKC Blackwood: 1430 — 5♣ = 1 or 4 key cards; 5♦ = 0 or 3 — **alertable**

Defense vs. Opponent's 1NT

WONT

Carding

- **Primary signal:** Attitude, then suit preference
- **vs. trump suit:** Lead A from AK

Other Conventions

- **New Minor Forcing:** After 1m – 1M – 1NT or 2NT, the other minor = forcing, asks about opener's shape — **alertable**

Alertable and Announced Bids Summary

> **Announced** = partner describes the bid aloud. **Alerted** = partner says "Alert" and waits for opponent to ask.

Announced (partner describes aloud):

Bid	What partner says
1NT opening	“15 to 17”
2NT opening	“20 to 21”
Jacoby Transfer (2♦/2♥ over NT)	“hearts/spades”
Texas Transfer (4♦/4♥ over NT)	“hearts/spades”

Alerted (partner says “Alert”):

Bid	Situation
Bergen 3♣	4-card support, 10–12 pts
Bergen 3♦	4-card support, 7–9 pts
3M raise	4-card support, 0–5 pts (preemptive)
Jacoby 2NT	Game-forcing raise, 4-card support
Splinter	Game-forcing raise, singleton/void
Drury 2♣	Passed hand, 3-card support
Drury 2♦	Passed hand, 4-card support
Inverted minor raise	Forcing, 10+ pts, no 4-card major
New Minor Forcing	After 1m – 1M – 1NT or 2NT
WONT 2♣/2♦/2♥/2♠/DBL	Over opponent’s 1NT opening

Notrump Responses

Covers responses to 1NT (15–17) and 2NT (20–21) openings.

1NT Responses

Majors	Responder Point Range		
	0–7 *Signoff*	**8–9** *Invitational*	**10+** *Game Forcing*
2–3 majors	Pass	2NT	3NT
4 or 4-4	Pass	Stayman and bid • No fit → 2NT • Fit → 3 of major	Stayman and bid to game • No fit → 3NT • Fit → 4 of major
5 in one major	Transfer and pass	Transfer and bid 2NT	Transfer and bid 3NT
6 in one major	Transfer and pass	Transfer and 3 of major	Transfer to game • No slam interest → Texas Transfer (4 level transfer) • Potential slam interest → Jacoby Transfer (2 level transfer)
5-4	Transfer and pass	Stayman and bid • No fit → 2 of 5-card major • Fit → 3 of major	Stayman and bid to game • No fit → 3 of 5-card major • Fit → 4 of major
6-4	Transfer and pass	Stayman and bid • No fit → 2 of 6-card major • Fit → 3 of major	Stayman and bid • No fit → 4 of 6-card major • Fit → 4 of major
5-5	Transfer and pass (best major)	Transfer to ♠ and bid • After transfer → 3♥	Transfer to ♠ and bid to game • After transfer → 4♥

Responses to 2NT (20–21)

No invitational zone — 4+ HCP opposite 20–21 is game-forcing. Stayman is 3♣; Jacoby Transfers are 3♦/3♥; 4NT is quantitative (not Blackwood).

With slam interest, follow the same game-forcing path to establish a fit, then pursue slam via RKC or — without a major fit — a quantitative 4NT. We have no firm agreements on exact point thresholds for slam tries opposite 2NT, so judge based on controls and fit.

Majors	Responder Point Range	
	0–3 *Pass*	**4+** *Game Forcing*
2–3 majors	Pass	3NT (or 4NT quantitative with slam values)
4 or 4-4	Pass	3♣ Stayman and bid to game • No fit → 3NT • Fit → 4 of major (or slam try if strong)
5 in one major	Pass	Transfer → bid 3NT (let opener choose 3NT or 4 of major)
6 in one major	Pass	Texas Transfer → 4 of major (no slam interest) Jacoby Transfer → cue bid or 4NT (slam interest)
5-4	Pass	3♣ Stayman and bid to game • No fit → 3 of 5-card major • Fit → 4 of major (or slam try if strong)
6-4	Pass	Texas Transfer → 4 of major (or Jacoby + side suit with slam interest)
5-5	Pass	Transfer to ♠ → bid 4♥

Texas Transfers

Used to transfer directly to game in a major, usually with a long suit and enough for game but no slam interest.

Auction: 1NT – 4♦ → opener bids 4♥; 1NT – 4♥ → opener bids 4♠

Responder bids	Transfers to
4♦	4♥ (game in hearts)
4♥	4♠ (game in spades)

When to use Texas vs. Jacoby: - Texas: game values, no slam interest, 6+ card major - Jacoby: game or slam possible, or need to describe hand further

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Major Raises

General Approach

- A simple raise to 2M covers two hands: 3-card support with 6–10 points, or exactly 6 points with 4-card support
- Use Bergen (3♣ or 3♦) to show 4-card support in the 7–12 point range
- Use a preemptive 3M to show 4-card support with 0–5 points (alertable)
- Use Splinter to show game-forcing 4 card support with a singleton or void. Usually the singleton or void is not an honor.
- Use Jacoby 2NT to show game-forcing **or better** 4 card support
- Use Drury with a passed hand to show 3+ card support and at least a minimum hand
- After a splinter bid, if opener has wasted honors in the short suit, opener usually will sign off in game

When to choose splinter or Jacoby 2NT

- A splinter usually is limited in point range to less-than-slam. It puts your partner in control of deciding how high.
- Because your honors are usually not in the splinter suit, partner could potentially explore slam if there’s a good fit in other suits and they don’t have many HCP in the splinter suit.
- Jacoby 2NT can be slam-worthy. It puts you in control of deciding how high.

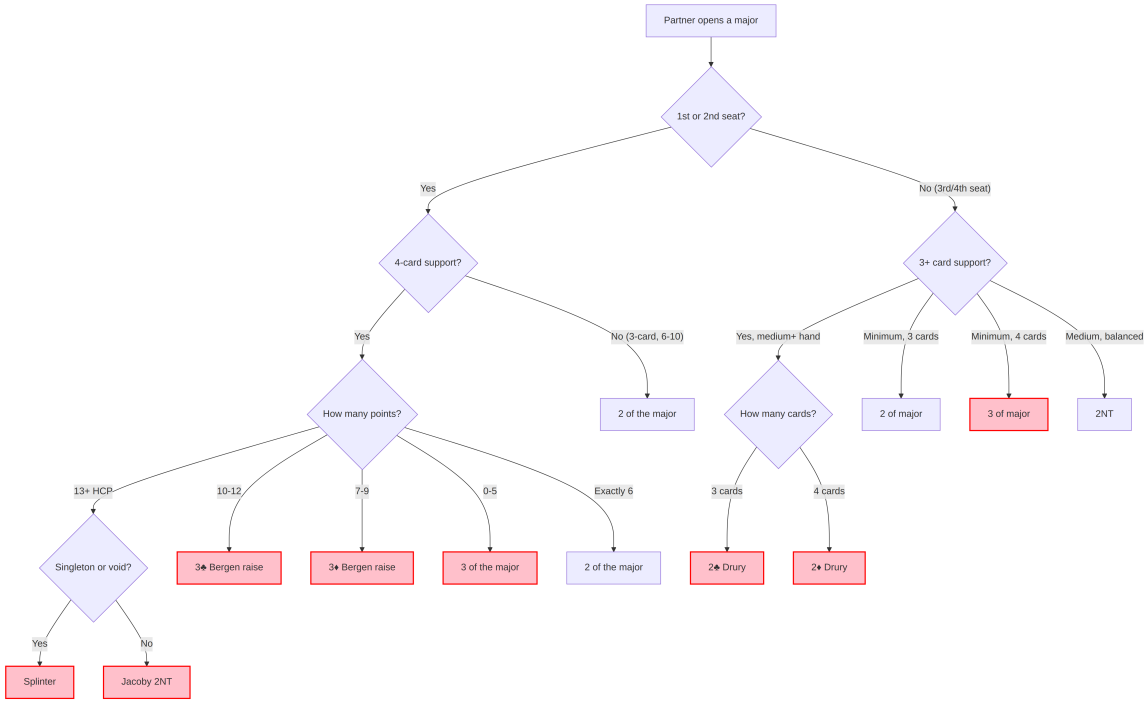

Diagram 1

Alertable

Inverted Minors

General approach: - Opener bids a minor. - Responder has no 4-card major, 10+ points, and support for opener's minor: - 1♣ opener: 5+ clubs required - 1♦ opener: 4+ diamonds required - Responder bids 2 of the minor. - Goal is to explore No Trump by figuring out which suits are stopped, or short-circuit to the minor if No Trump isn't viable

Responder bids after 1 of a minor by opener

Bid	Range	Notes
3m	0-5	5+ card support (alert)
1NT	6-9	
2m	10+	5+ clubs / 4+ diamonds (alert)

Opener rebids after 1m - 2m

Bid	Range	Notes
2♣/2♦/2♥/ 2♠	12-14	Bid stoppers up the line
3m	12-14	no stoppers. non-forcing
2NT	=14	All higher-ranking suits stopped. Non-forcing. Picture bid
2♣/2♦/2♥/ 2♠	15+	No singleton or void. Bid stoppers up the line. Opener is responsible for making sure the auction does not stop below 3NT
3NT	18-19	Balanced hand with 18-19

Asking for a stopper

Once 3 of the 4 suits have been spoken for, a bid of the 4th suit is 'asking'.

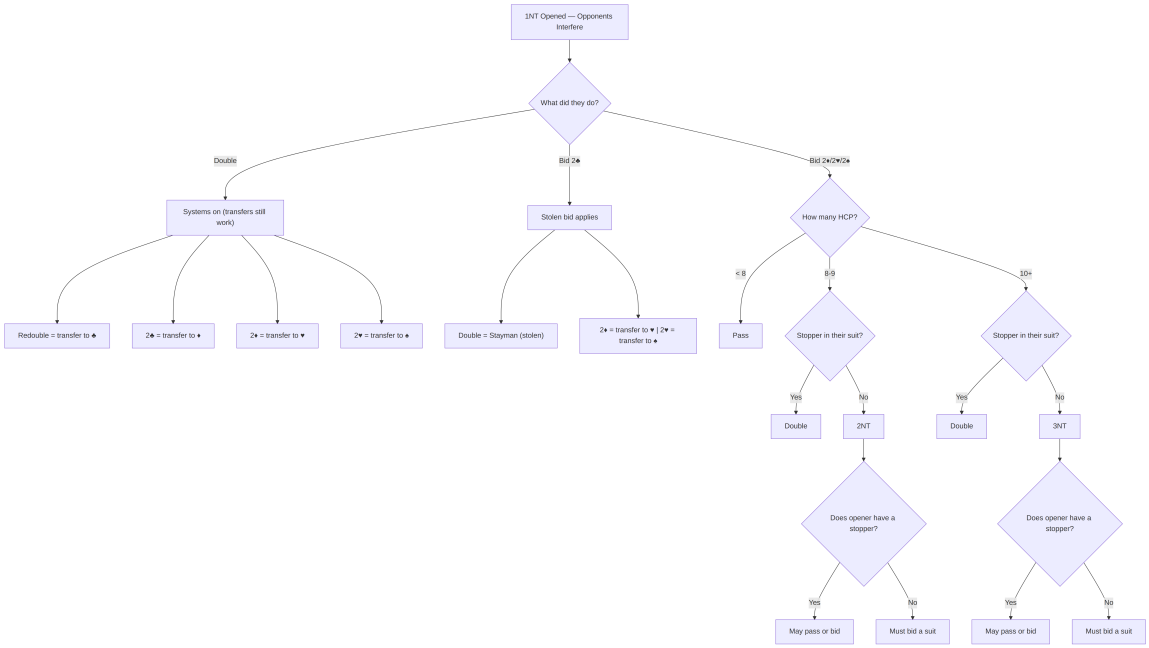
1NT Opened — Opponents Interfere
What did they do?
Double
Bid 2♣
Bid 2♦/2♥/2♠
Systems on (transfers still work)
Stolen bid applies
How many HCP?
< 8
8-9
10+
Redouble = transfer to ♣
2♣ = transfer to ♦
2♦ = transfer to ♥
2♥ = transfer to ♠
Double = Stayman (stolen)
2♦ = transfer to ♥ | 2♥ = transfer to ♠
Pass
Stopper in their suit?
Stopper in their suit?
Yes
No
Yes
No
Double
2NT
Double
3NT
Does opener have a stopper?
Does opener have a stopper?
Yes
No
Yes
No
May pass or bid
Must bid a suit
May pass or bid
Must bid a suit

Diagram 1

Support Doubles and Redoubles

Used by opener to show 3-card support for responder's major when opponents interfere.

Support Double

When it applies: Opener has opened, responder bid a major, and an opponent overcalls (through 2♠).

Auction example: 1♣ – (P) – 1♥ – (1♠) – **Dbl** = opener has exactly 3 hearts

Opener's action	Meaning
Double	Exactly 3-card support for responder's major
Raise to 2M	4-card support

Why it matters: Responder now knows whether to expect 3- or 4-card support when bidding game or slam, which affects how they evaluate their hand.

After the support double, responder knows opener has exactly 3-card support. Responder's options:

Responder action	Meaning
2 of own major	Minimum hand; **does NOT promise 5 cards** — may be only 4
3 of own major	Invitational (typically 8–10 pts with 5+ cards)
2NT	Invitational (8–10 pts, no major interest)
3NT / 4M	Game-forcing, places contract
New suit	Natural and forcing (game interest)
Pass	Convert to penalty double; Happy to defend against their overcall

Key principle: Rebidding the major at the 2-level after a support double is a minimum, non-forcing action. It does **not** promise 5 cards in the major — opener has shown 3, and together you know you have a 7-card fit (possibly 8 if responder holds 5). Responder passes or raises based on combined values, not assumed trump count.

With 3-card support from opener: - 7-card fit (4+3) is playable but not ideal — prefer NT at higher point counts if the hand is balanced. - 8-card fit (5+3) plays normally — bid the major.

Support Redouble

When it applies: Same situation as the support double, but the opponent **doubles** instead of overcalling.

Auction example: 1♣ – (P) – 1♥ – (Dbl) – **Rdbl** = opener has 3-card support for hearts

Opener's action	Meaning
Redouble	3-card support for responder's major
Raise to 2M	4-card support

Applies through: 2♠ (same as support double)

Roman Keycard Blackwood (RKC 1430)

Used to count key cards (the four aces plus the king of trumps) before bidding slam.

The Ask

4NT = asking for key cards (must have a clearly established trump suit)

The “1430” naming refers to the responses:

Response	Key cards held
5♣	1 or 4 key cards
5♦	0 or 3 key cards
5♥	2 key cards, **no** trump queen
5♠	2 key cards, **with** trump queen
5NT	2 key cards and a **void**

The Queen Ask

After a 5♣ or 5♦ response: - **5 of trumps** = sign off (not interested in the queen) - **Cheapest bid that is not trumps** = queen ask

Response to queen ask	Meaning
5 of trumps (or 6 if forced)	No trump queen
6 of trumps	Has trump queen

Examples: - Trumps are **spades**, response 5♣: 5♦ (queen ask) – 5♠ (no) / 6♠ (yes). Sign off = 5♠ directly. - Trumps are **spades**, response 5♦: 5♥ (queen ask) – 5♠ (no) / 6♠ (yes). Sign off = 5♠ directly. - Trumps are **hearts**, response 5♣: 5♦ (queen ask) – 5♥ (no) / 6♥ (yes). Sign off = 5♥ directly. - Trumps are **hearts**, response 5♦: 5♠ (queen ask) – but now “no” = 6♥, so you’re already at slam.

The queen ask can force you to the 6-level — this happens with hearts (after a 5♦ response) and always with minors. Only ask for the queen when you can afford to be at 6 if the answer is no, or when trumps are spades (always safe). This is part of why the guidelines below warn against using RKC when you could be forced past 5 of trumps.

When to Use / When NOT to Use RKC

Use 4NT when: - Trump suit is clearly agreed or unambiguously implied - You have no two fast losers in any side suit - You're in slam-investigation range and need keycard information

Don't use 4NT when: - **You have a void** — partner's key card in your void suit is worthless, and you can't evaluate accurately. Use cue bids instead, or Exclusion Blackwood if you play it. - **No trump suit is agreed** — 4NT is ambiguous and might be natural/quantitative after a NT opening or when no suit has been bid and supported. - **You're not in slam range** — don't fish for information you won't act on. - **You'd be forced past 5 of trumps** — if the response could land you at the 6-level with two keycards missing, don't ask. - **After 1NT or 2NT** without an agreed fit — 4NT is quantitative, not Blackwood. - **Partner has shown a very weak hand** — Blackwood can't fix a bad trump suit or missing controls in side suits.

New Minor Forcing

Used by responder after a 1NT or 2NT rebid by opener to ask about opener's shape, particularly major-suit length.

When It Applies

Auction: 1m – 1M – 1NT – 2♣ or 2♦ (the *other* minor = new minor) **Auction:** 1m – 1M – 2NT – 3♣ or 3♦ (the *other* minor = new minor)

- Responder bids the **unbid minor** as an artificial, forcing bid
- Does **not** show clubs/diamonds — it's asking opener to describe further

Requirements for responder: - Invitational or better values (typically 10+ HCP) - Wants more information before placing the contract

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Opener's Responses

Priorities (in order from most important to least): 1. Bid the other major if you have 4+ cards in it. 2. Bid partner's major if you have 3 card support in it. 3. Show your range or shape otherwise

Opener rebid	Meaning
2M (responder's major)	3-card support
2♥ (if spades was the major)	4 hearts
2NT	Minimum, no 3-card major support
3M	3-card support, maximum
3NT	Maximum, balanced

What Is NOT New Minor Forcing

- If partner has not rebid 1NT or 2NT, it's not new minor forcing if you bid a new minor. Partner will expect that you probably have that minor
- If no majors have been bid before the 1NT or 2NT, it's not new minor forcing

WONT

Defense convention used over an opponent’s 1NT opening. Modified version of DONT

The Convention

- 2♣ - clubs and another suit, with a 5-4 or better shape
  - Advancer passes if clubs is not the worst possible suit
  - If it is the worst possible suit, advancer bids 2♦ and overcaller passes or corrects
- 2♦ - Diamonds and a major (5-4 or better)
  - Advancer passes if Diamonds is not the worst possible suit
  - If it is the worst possible suit, advancer bids 2♥ and overcaller passes or corrects
- 2♥ - 6+ hearts
- 2♠ - 6+ spades
- Double - EITHER a 6-card minor or 5-4 majors - relay bid
  - Advancer must bid 2♣
  - With a 6 card minor, overcaller will bid it
  - With both majors, overcaller will bid 2H, and advancer will pass or correct

Michaels Cuebid

A cuebid of opener's suit to show a two-suited hand.

The Convention

After an opponent opens 1 of a suit, a **direct cuebid** (2 of opener's suit) shows a specific two-suiter:

Opponent opens	Your cuebid	Shows
1♣	2♣	Both majors (5+ hearts and 5+ spades)
1♦	2♦	Both majors (5+ hearts and 5+ spades)
1♥	2♥	Spades + an unspecified minor
1♠	2♠	Hearts + an unspecified minor

Point Range / Strength

Generally a strong enough hand that we might win the auction. If you expect opponents will win the auction because your hand is so weak, don't bid Michael's because it gives the opponents too much information.

Responses by Partner (Advancer)

Advancer bid	Meaning
2M (known major)	Preference, not forcing
3M (known major)	Invitational
4M (known major)	To play
2NT	Asks for the minor (if applicable)

Unusual 2NT

A jump to 2NT over an opponent's opening bid to show the **two lowest unbid suits**.

The Convention

2NT (jump) over an opponent's opening = 5+ cards in each of the two lowest unbid suits

Opponent opens	Your 2NT shows
1♥	Clubs and diamonds (the two lowest unbid suits)
1♠	Clubs and diamonds
1♣	Diamonds and hearts
1♦	Clubs and hearts

Point Range / Strength

Unusual 2NT is primarily a **shape bid**, not an HCP bid — suit quality and distribution matter more than point count.

Vulnerability	Typical strength
Not vulnerable	~6–11 HCP; prioritize suit quality over points
Vulnerable	~8–11+ HCP; suits should be headed by at least a Q or better

With 12+ HCP and 5-5 shape, the hand may be strong enough to act differently (e.g., overcall then bid again). Very strong 5-5 hands should usually not preempt with 2NT — they deserve more.

Responses by Partner (Advancer)

Advancer **must** choose a suit — the 2NT bidder has shown 5-5, so partner picks the better fit.

Advancer bid	Meaning
3 of lower suit	Preference, to play; weak hand (0–8)
3 of higher suit	Preference, to play; weak hand (0–8)
4 of lower suit	Preemptive; good fit, weak hand
4 of higher suit	Preemptive; good fit, weak hand
Cue bid of opponent's suit	Game-forcing; asks 2NT bidder to clarify better/longer suit

Cue bid = "I want to be in game, tell me more." The 2NT bidder rebids the longer or better suit, which advancer converts to game.

Unusual 2NT vs. Natural 2NT

A 2NT overcall is **unusual** (showing two-suited hand) when made as a direct jump over an opening bid at the 1-level.

A 2NT bid is **not Unusual** when: - Made over an opponent's **1NT** opening — we play WONT instead - Made after an opponent's weak two-bid (e.g., 2♠ – **2NT** = natural, strong balanced 15–18) - Made as a response or rebid in an uncontested auction

When in doubt: if a natural 2NT makes sense given the auction, treat it as natural. If it's a jump overcall over a **suit** opening at the 1-level, it's unusual.